

have come to yield step by step to the onward march of civilization, that mankind has been able to spare time from its preoccupation with the struggle for existence to think about the struggle for a standard of living.

It is in his economic capacity that man provides himself with food, clothing, shelter and amusement. In proportion as the risks of war and disease are mitigated by the progress of civilization, the risks attendant upon his economic life become more and more a claim to his attention and his constructive efforts. It is thus quite probable that the present movement to stabilize business and economic affairs will prove one of the greatest problems of the present century. Genuine achievement in the way of reducing the needless risks of business is, therefore, something more than the neat solution of a merely abstract economic problem. It is an indispensable contribution to the better and fuller flowering of civilization, in even its highest and most spiritual aspects. It makes directly for the more intense and satisfying enjoyment of life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness by all the race.

In its risky and uncertain youth, America had more excuse for constant tumult and fickleness in its business affairs than it has today, when the United States has so obviously attained the fuller powers of economic maturity. Many of us here tonight can recall quite clearly the great business crises which occurred in this country in 1907, in 1914, and again in 1920—all within the last twenty years. Certainly none of us would choose to conduct his business through another crisis of the same kind if he could help it. It is a practically universal feeling on the part of American business men that prompts the common present-day question, "Can catastrophes in trade be actually prevented in the future by stabilizing business—and if so, how?"

Certainly in the vigorous cooperative effort which American business has made since the panic of 1907 to prevent another such occurrence in the future, one of the most important and most constructive accomplishments has been